

Unifying Theory of Dynamic Aether Mechanics: Quantum Mechanics

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Abstract

Within the Dynamic Aether Mechanics framework, quantum phenomena emerge from the properties of a quantum superfluid with a logarithmic equation of state. This paper derives wave–particle duality from extended condensate excitations (photons as spin-wave modes of the spinor condensate, with Derrick’s theorem forbidding stable localized particles in free space) that condense near matter via the Dynamic Casimir Effect. Energy quantization arises from angular phase-matching conditions in the atomic resonant cavity formed by the nuclear flow gradient, reproducing the hydrogen energy levels $E_n = -13.6/n^2$ eV and all spectral series. The Pauli exclusion principle follows from topological vortex interactions: same-circulation vortices cannot share a spatial mode because their superposed velocity fields carry divergent energy. The Schrödinger equation is recovered via the Madelung inverse construction with Wallstrom’s topological quantization condition resolved by the quantized circulation of the medium. The electron is identified as a quantized vortex ring with mass determined by $m_e c^2 = \frac{1}{2} \rho_A \kappa_e^2 r_{\text{loop}} [\ln(8r_{\text{loop}}/\xi) - \frac{1}{2}]$.

This paper is part of a series presenting the Unifying Theory of Dynamic Aether Mechanics. For the foundational concepts of Aether binding, the three independent properties (density, pressure, temperature), and the unification of force constants, see Paper 1: General Overview [35].

1. Wave–Particle Duality

1.1 Photons as Spin-Wave Excitations of the Condensate

The quantum superfluid framework developed in Section 4 establishes the Aether as a spinor condensate with order parameter $\Psi = (\psi_\uparrow, \psi_\downarrow)$. This spinor structure supports spin-wave excitations: modes in which the two components oscillate in antiphase ($\delta\psi_\uparrow = -\delta\psi_\downarrow$), modulating the local spin orientation of the condensate without changing the total density. Photons are identified with these spin-wave modes. At macroscopic wavelengths (all observable light), spin-orbit coupling produces effective mass currents from the spin oscillation, making the photon indistinguishable

from a first-sound perturbation; the effective propagation speed is therefore the two-fluid first-sound speed c_1 (Paper 6 [37], Section 5.1), which is relevant for dark matter lensing consistency.

Two transverse polarization states arise because the spin-wave mode carries a vector degree of freedom: the direction of the spinor oscillation in the internal $(\psi_\uparrow, \psi_\downarrow)$ space. This direction projects onto two independent components, corresponding to the two physical polarizations of light. In laboratory spinor BECs, these spin-wave excitations are well-studied and propagate as gapless Goldstone modes when the system has continuous spin-rotation symmetry [27].

The spatial transversality of these modes—the requirement that the oscillation direction is perpendicular to the propagation direction—follows from spin-orbit coupling in the condensate. In superfluid helium-3 (the A-phase), Volovik showed that spin-orbit locking ties the internal spinor direction to the spatial orientation of the order parameter, producing emergent transverse gauge bosons from the condensate’s Goldstone modes [15]. The same mechanism applies here: the Aether condensate’s spinor structure, combined with the spin-orbit interaction that relates the internal spin direction to the spatial wave vector, ensures that the spin-wave excitations are transverse.

The spin-wave dispersion relation is $\omega = c k$ —exactly non-dispersive: all frequencies travel at the same speed c . This is confirmed to extraordinary precision by the Fermi LAT gamma-ray timing constraints, which constrain Lorentz-violating photon dispersion to energy scales above $7.6 E_{\text{Planck}}$ [11]. Since photons propagate in the spin-wave channel, this constrains the *spin* healing length $\xi_s \ll \xi$, consistent with the spin-wave channel being vastly stiffer than the density channel (Section 4.8).

The contrast with gluons is instructive. Photons propagate through *unbound* Aether, whose response is confirmed to be perfectly linear (Hookean) to 10^{-8} precision [1]. Gluons are excitations of *compressed* bridge material—a dense condensate strand whose nonlinear properties produce the self-interactions that distinguish the strong force from electromagnetism. The distinction is one of medium: the linear bulk condensate versus the nonlinear compressed strand.

Connection to the flow-vector description. Paper 4 [38] describes the electric field as the Aether “flow vector” and the magnetic field as its vorticity—a macroscopic velocity-field picture. This is not in conflict with the spin-wave identification. In superfluid helium-3, Volovik [15] showed that spin-wave Goldstone modes, through spin-orbit coupling, produce effective mass currents indistinguishable from velocity-field perturbations at macroscopic scales. The same mechanism applies here: the internal spinor oscillation (the microscopic reality) couples to the spatial velocity field through spin-orbit locking, producing the flow patterns that Paper 4 describes as the electric and magnetic fields. The “flow vector” is the macroscopic effective description of what is microscopically a spin-wave excitation; in the bound-state picture of Paper 4, this flow vector is the instantaneous displacement of the coherent axial-oscillation wave field of a charged particle’s bound core ring—a localized, standing-wave form of the same fundamental spin-wave degree of freedom that propagates as free electromagnetic radiation.

A quantitative derivation showing that the spin-wave dispersion relation reproduces Maxwell’s equations in full—including the transversality condition $\mathbf{k} \cdot \mathbf{E} = 0$ and the absence of a longitudinal photon—requires specifying the spin-orbit coupling Hamiltonian of the Aether condensate and remains an open calculation.

1.2 Why Photons Cannot Be Localized Particles in Free Space

The Derrick scaling analysis (Section 4.7) proves that no stable, localized three-dimensional field configuration exists in the logarithmic condensate. Under uniform rescaling $\psi(\mathbf{r}) \rightarrow \psi(\mathbf{r}/L)$, the energy of any localized perturbation scales as $E(L) = AL + BL^3$ with $A, B > 0$. Since this is monotonically increasing, the configuration always lowers its energy by shrinking to zero size—there is no stable soliton.

This result is a *feature*, not a limitation. It explains why photons propagate as extended waves rather than as compact particles: the unbound Aether simply does not support stable localized excitations. A “photon particle” in free space would be an unstable configuration that immediately disperses back into a wave. Stable localized structures (electrons, quarks) require a different topological mechanism—quantized circulation—which photons lack because they carry no topological charge.

1.3 Energy Quantization: $E = h\nu$

The condensate obeys bosonic commutation relations $[\hat{a}, \hat{a}^\dagger] = 1$ (Section 4), permitting unlimited occupation of each mode but requiring that each mode’s energy comes in discrete quanta. The quantum of action h that sets the vortex circulation quantum $\kappa_0 = h/m_A$ also sets the minimum energy per wave mode: $E = h\nu$. Energy quantization of light is not an independent postulate—it follows from the same quantum structure of the medium that produces circulation quantization and the Pauli exclusion principle.

1.4 Wave-to-Particle Transition Near Matter

If photons cannot exist as stable particles in free space, what happens when light is detected? Every atom generates a near-field coherent axial-oscillation wave field around its nucleus (its electric field; Section 2 [38]), whose time-averaged pressure envelope creates a velocity gradient that is strongest near the nucleus. When a propagating wave enters this strong-gradient environment:

1. The pressure-gradient refracts the wave inward, compressing it spatially—analogueous to how sound is bent and concentrated by wind shear in the atmosphere.
2. The local energy density increases as the same wave energy is concentrated into a smaller volume.

3. The rapidly moving vortex boundaries of atomic electrons provide the conditions for the Dynamic Casimir Effect: fluctuations in the wave are amplified at the oscillating boundary, facilitating the conversion of distributed wave energy into a localized excitation.

Detection is therefore a physical process: the wave condenses into a localized energy deposit at a specific atom. This is not a “wavefunction collapse” requiring an external postulate—it is the natural behavior of a spin-wave excitation entering a strong-gradient region bounded by oscillating vortex structures. (The Derrick analysis of Section 4.7 applies to the *uniform* condensate; the atomic environment’s steep pressure gradient and oscillating vortex boundaries modify the energy functional, enabling localized energy transfer that is forbidden in free space.)

1.5 The Double-Slit Experiment and Its Variants

The double-slit experiment is resolved without invoking complementarity or observer-dependent collapse. Between source and screen, the photon is a spin-wave excitation obeying exact superposition—it passes through both slits and interferes with itself, identically to any classical wave in a linear medium. At the screen, each atom’s strong-inflow environment condenses the wave energy into a localized detection event (probability $\propto |\psi|^2$), building up the interference pattern one event at a time. Which-path detection destroys the pattern not because “observation collapses the wave” but because the detector’s vortex-boundary interactions extract energy and disrupt phase coherence.

This framework naturally accommodates all major variants: single-photon interference [16, 17] (each excitation interferes with itself); massive-particle interference up to 25,000 amu molecules [18] (all particles are condensate excitations with de Broglie wavelength $\lambda = h/(mv)$); Wheeler’s delayed-choice experiment [19, 20] (the wave always propagates through both arms—no retrocausality, just delayed boundary conditions); interaction-free measurement [21, 22] (absence of a wave component eliminates destructive interference); and the continuous $V^2 + D^2 \leq 1$ complementarity tradeoff [23] (partial scattering proportionally disrupts phase coherence). Decoherence of large molecules follows from thermal photon emission carrying which-path information, with no fundamental cutoff.

1.6 Entanglement-Dependent Experiments

Two further double-slit variants—the quantum eraser and the delayed-choice quantum eraser—involve entangled particle pairs. Their explanation within the Aether framework draws on the non-separability of correlated condensate excitations (Section 1.6.1): because both members of an entangled pair are topologically bound features of a single quantum condensate, their joint state cannot be factored into independent descriptions. The experimental results follow naturally from this wave-based picture.

The quantum eraser (Scully and Drühl 1982 [24]). Photons passing through a double slit are

tagged with which-path information by coupling each path to an orthogonal polarization state (or an auxiliary quantum system). With the tags intact, no interference is observed—orthogonal Aether wave modes do not superpose. However, a subsequent measurement that projects the tagging system onto a basis that mixes the two tags (“erasing” the which-path information) restores interference in the corresponding sub-ensemble. In the Aether model, the tagged waves are spin-wave modes with orthogonal polarization structures (distinct patterns of the spinor order parameter). Orthogonal modes do not interfere, just as orthogonally polarized classical waves produce no fringe pattern. The eraser measurement reprojects the wave onto a shared polarization basis, recovering the coherence needed for interference in that subset of events. The total pattern (summed over all tagging outcomes) never shows fringes, because the fringe and anti-fringe sub-ensembles cancel exactly.

The delayed-choice quantum eraser (Kim et al. 2000 [25]). Entangled photon pairs are produced via spontaneous parametric down-conversion. The “signal” photon passes through a double slit and is detected at a screen; the “idler” photon travels a longer path to one of several detectors. Depending on which detector registers the idler, the which-path information is either preserved or erased. The idler detection can occur *after* the signal photon has already been recorded.

The total signal-photon pattern shows no interference—it is featureless. But when the data is sorted by idler outcome, the sub-ensemble whose idlers reached the erasure detectors reveals interference fringes (and anti-fringes), while the sub-ensemble whose idlers reached the which-path detectors shows none.

In the Aether framework, the entangled pair originates as two correlated spin-wave excitations produced simultaneously in the down-conversion process. The correlations—encoded in the joint polarization and phase structure of the two waves—are established at the source, not imposed retroactively by measurement. The signal wave at the screen carries these correlations as substructure that is invisible in the total intensity pattern but becomes apparent when the data is sorted by the idler’s outcome. The idler measurement does not *change* what happened to the signal; it *sorts* the signal events into pre-existing correlated sub-ensembles. No faster-than-light influence is required, and no retrocausality is invoked.

1.6.1 Entanglement as Condensate Non-Separability

The preceding explanations of the quantum eraser and delayed-choice quantum eraser rest on the claim that correlated wave pairs maintain a joint quantum state that cannot be factored into independent single-wave descriptions. Within the Aether framework, this non-separability is not an additional postulate—it follows directly from the binding principle established in Section 2.

The core axiom of the theory is that all matter and radiation are excitations of a single quantum superfluid condensate described by a spinor order parameter $\Psi = (\psi_{\uparrow}, \psi_{\downarrow})$. Particles are not objects placed *in* the Aether; they are topological deformations *of* it—vortex rings, compression solitons,

and bridge structures that cannot be separated from the condensate. This binding is what gives them mass, confinement, and stability.

The same binding principle that explains confinement also addresses entanglement. When two correlated excitations are produced—for example, a photon pair from spontaneous parametric down-conversion, or a particle–antiparticle pair from vacuum fluctuations—they are not two independent objects that happen to share information. They are two correlated features of a single quantum field that were never separate to begin with. The condensate’s wavefunction is one state, not two, and the correlations between excitations are encoded in that global state from the moment of creation.

Why this resolves the Bell inequality challenge. Bell’s theorem [26] proves that no theory based on *local hidden variables* can reproduce the correlations predicted by quantum mechanics. The key assumption in Bell’s proof is *separability*: that the joint probability of outcomes at two detectors factors into independent probabilities, each depending only on its local hidden variable and the local detector setting. A classical fluid with pre-determined wave properties would satisfy this assumption and would therefore obey Bell’s inequality.

The Aether condensate is not a classical fluid. It is a quantum superfluid whose excitations obey bosonic commutation relations $[\hat{a}, \hat{a}^\dagger] = 1$ (Section 4). Two correlated excitations of this condensate share a joint quantum state that does not factor into independent local descriptions—the separability assumption fails. This is not a signal propagating between the excitations, nor a hidden variable carried by each; it is the irreducible quantum coherence of the medium itself.

BEC pair production as a direct analogue. This mechanism is not speculative—it is observed in laboratory Bose–Einstein condensates. Bogoliubov excitations of a BEC naturally arise in correlated momentum pairs $(k, -k)$ that are entangled by construction [14]. These pairs violate classical correlation bounds precisely because they are excitations of a single quantum field, not independent classical objects. In the Aether framework, photon pair production (SPDC) is the cosmological-scale analogue of Bogoliubov pair production: the same quantum statistics that produce entangled phonon pairs in a laboratory BEC produce entangled photon pairs in the Aether condensate.

No-signaling is automatic. Because the total detection pattern at either detector is completely featureless without post-selection—the marginal distribution at each detector is uniform regardless of what happens at the other—no information is transmitted faster than light. The non-local correlations are only revealed when results from both detectors are compared after the fact. This is consistent with the theory’s requirement that all causal influences propagate at or below the local speed of sound $c_s = \sqrt{K_A/\rho_A}$ (which equals c at ambient density).

The Aether framework thus provides a physical picture of entanglement: it is the quantum coherence of the condensate ground state, inherited by excitation pairs through the binding that ties all matter and radiation to the same underlying field. The same mechanism that confines quarks inside protons (topological binding to the condensate) also explains why entangled photons violate Bell inequalities (they are correlated excitations of the quantum field they are bound to). A formal derivation showing

that the condensate's field operators produce exactly the Bell-violating correlations predicted by quantum mechanics remains an important goal for future work.

1.7 The Photoelectric Effect

The photoelectric effect ($E = h\nu$, threshold at the work function) is retained with one change in physical picture: the incoming spin-wave excitation condenses into a localized quantum at a single surface atom through the DCE mechanism described in Section 1.4. The instantaneous response follows because the wave energy is already distributed across the surface—condensation occurs on atomic timescales, not classical accumulation timescales.

2. Energy Quantization and Atomic Spectra

The preceding sections establish that the Aether is a physical medium with density ρ_A , bulk modulus K_A , and a wave speed $c = \sqrt{K_A/\rho_A}$ that is constant in the free medium. The electric field is the coherent axial-oscillation wave field of the bound core ring (Paper 4 [38]), and every atom generates a structured near-field pressure environment through the nucleus's wave emission. A natural question follows: if the Aether is a real medium that supports waves, and if atoms create structured near-field environments in this medium, then atoms should function as resonant cavities—and their energy levels should be discrete for the same reason that a vibrating drumhead or an organ pipe supports only certain frequencies.

This section develops that connection.

2.1 The Atomic Resonant Cavity

Every nucleus generates a near-field coherent axial-oscillation wave field (its electric field), whose time-averaged pressure envelope creates a velocity gradient that is strongest near the nucleus and weakens with distance. This velocity gradient constitutes a refractive environment: waves propagating tangentially are refracted inward by the near-field pressure-gradient shear, analogous to how sound is bent by wind gradients in the atmosphere.

An electron in this framework is a permanent Aether binding—a spinning vortex that is itself a wave-like disturbance in the medium. When an electron is bound to a nucleus, its wave structure must be self-consistent within the density environment created by the nucleus. Specifically, the electron's wave must satisfy two conditions:

1. **Angular phase matching.** After propagating around one complete orbit, the wave must return to the same phase—it must constructively interfere with itself. If it does not, destructive

interference eliminates the mode. This requires an integer number of wavelengths around the orbital path:

$$n\lambda = 2\pi r \quad (1)$$

where n is a positive integer and λ is the de Broglie wavelength of the electron in the Aether medium. This is identical to the condition that selects resonant modes on a vibrating ring or in a whispering gallery: the wave must close on itself.

2. **Radial confinement.** The near-field pressure gradient creates an effective boundary. Near the nucleus, the strong gradient refracts the electron wave inward—confined. At large distances, the near-field wave envelope weakens and the confining effect vanishes. Only certain radial profiles produce standing waves that remain bound (decaying at large r) rather than radiating away into the medium. Non-resonant radial modes leak energy into the surrounding Aether and cannot persist.

Together, these two conditions—angular phase matching and radial confinement—select a discrete set of resonant modes from the continuous spectrum of possibilities. Each mode is labeled by integers: the principal quantum number n (total number of nodes), the angular quantum number l (angular nodes), and the magnetic quantum number m (orientation of the angular pattern). This is directly analogous to the modes of a vibrating drumhead, which are labeled by the number of radial nodes and the number of angular nodal lines, and whose allowed frequencies are determined by the zeros of Bessel functions.

The critical distinction from standard quantum mechanics is that in the Aether model, the boundary conditions have a physical origin: the flow structure of the medium creates the cavity. The electron wave is not an abstract probability amplitude—it is a real disturbance in a real medium, confined by the refractive properties of that medium.

2.2 Derivation of Energy Levels

The energy levels of hydrogen can be derived from the resonance condition combined with the Coulomb force balance. The electron, treated as a wave in the Aether medium, has a de Broglie wavelength determined by its momentum:

$$\lambda = \frac{h}{m_e v} \quad (2)$$

The angular phase-matching condition $n\lambda = 2\pi r$ gives the quantization of angular momentum, $m_e v r = n\hbar$ —not as an axiom, but as a consequence of requiring constructive self-interference of a wave propagating in the Aether around a closed path. Combining this with the Coulomb force balance $ke^2/r^2 = m_e v^2/r$ yields quantized radii $r_n = a_0 n^2$ (where $a_0 = \hbar^2/(m_e k e^2) = 0.529 \text{ \AA}$ is

the Bohr radius), and orbital velocities $v_n = \alpha c/n$, where $\alpha = ke^2/(\hbar c) \approx 1/137$. The fine structure constant thus acquires a direct physical meaning: it is the ratio of the electron's orbital velocity to the wave speed of the medium, analogous to a Mach number. That $\alpha \ll 1$ confirms that atomic physics is deeply non-relativistic—the electron's motion is a small perturbation of the Aether.

The total energy of each resonant mode is:

$$E_n = -\frac{1}{2} \alpha^2 m_e c^2 \cdot \frac{1}{n^2} = -\frac{13.6 \text{ eV}}{n^2} \quad (3)$$

This result connects three quantities that already have Aether interpretations in this theory: $c = \sqrt{K_A/\rho_A}$ (wave speed), α (electron flow strength relative to the medium), and $m_e c^2$ (the rest energy of the permanent binding). The ground state energy of hydrogen is not an independent parameter—it is determined by the same medium properties that govern electromagnetism and wave propagation.

2.3 Consistency with Standard Atomic Physics

The resonant cavity model reproduces all standard results of atomic spectroscopy without modification. The virial theorem ($T = -E$, $V = 2E$) follows from the $1/r$ potential. Spectral lines match the Rydberg formula $R_\infty = \alpha^2 m_e c/(2h) = 1.0974 \times 10^7 \text{ m}^{-1}$, giving Lyman- α at 121.6 nm, H- α at 656.3 nm, and the Lyman limit at 91.2 nm (= 13.6 eV).

The cavity model reproduces all standard results of atomic spectroscopy without modification: selection rules (from angular momentum exchange between the medium and the transitioning mode), fine structure (from spin-orbit coupling of the electron vortex with its own Aether flow), hyperfine structure including the 21-cm line at 1420.405 MHz (from coupling between electron and proton vortex flows), Zeeman and Stark effects (from external Aether flow perturbations splitting the cavity modes), multi-electron shell filling, the quantum defect formula, and exotic systems (positronium, muonic hydrogen). All follow from the Aether resonance conditions without additional assumptions.

3. The Pauli Exclusion Principle: Topological Vortex Exclusion

One of the deepest results in quantum mechanics is the Pauli exclusion principle: no two identical fermions (half-integer spin particles) can simultaneously occupy the same quantum state. For electrons in atoms, this means no two electrons can share all four quantum numbers (n, l, m_l, m_s). The exclusion principle governs the structure of the periodic table, the stability of matter, and the properties of every material substance.

Despite its foundational importance, the spin-statistics theorem—which connects half-integer spin to antisymmetric wavefunctions—has resisted elementary explanation. Feynman remarked in 1963 that he could not provide one. The proofs of Fierz (1939) and Pauli (1940) require abstract axioms

(Lorentz invariance, positive energy, microcausality), and Duck and Sudarshan’s comprehensive review [2] concluded that the connection between spin and statistics remains one of the least intuitively understood results in physics.

The Aether vortex model offers a physical picture: the exclusion principle arises from the *topological instability of multiply quantized vortices*.

3.1 Electrons as Topological Vortices

In this theory, an electron is a persistent spin vortex in the Aether—a circulatory flow pattern with quantized angular momentum $\pm\hbar/2$. The vortex has a well-defined *phase winding*: the Aether flow completes a 2π phase rotation around the vortex core. This 2π winding is the defining topological characteristic of a spin- $\frac{1}{2}$ object. In the two-fluid model (Paper 6 [37]), the electron vortex is a quantized circulation in the *superfluid condensate*; all particle structure, binding, and electromagnetic phenomena are condensate dynamics. The normal component (thermal excitations) does not support stable vortices and is relevant only for the cosmological thermal structure discussed in Paper 6.

Two fundamental properties of vortex topology are relevant:

1. **Topological charge conservation.** In any medium supporting quantized vortices, the total topological charge (net winding number) is conserved. Vortices are created and destroyed only in pairs of opposite winding. This is confirmed experimentally in superfluid helium and Bose–Einstein condensates [5].
2. **The double-cover property.** A spin- $\frac{1}{2}$ vortex requires a 4π (720°) rotation to return to its original state; a 2π rotation produces a sign change. This is the physical content of the SU(2) double cover of SO(3), demonstrated by Dirac’s belt trick: a vortex tethered to the surrounding medium by its flow field cannot be untwisted by a single 360° rotation, but can be untwisted by 720° . In the Aether model, electron vortices are literally tethered to the medium through their circulation, giving the belt trick a direct physical realization.

3.2 Why Same-Spin Vortices Cannot Share an Orbital

Consider two electron vortices placed in the same resonant cavity mode (same n, l, m_l) with the *same* spin orientation (same m_s —same circulation direction). Their phase windings superpose:

$$\text{Same spin: } 2\pi + 2\pi = 4\pi \quad (\text{net winding}) \tag{4}$$

A 4π phase winding is topologically equivalent to a spin-1 object—a boson, not two fermions. The system has undergone a topological transition that changes its statistical character. This is physically forbidden for two reasons:

Energetic instability. A vortex with winding number s has kinetic energy proportional to s^2 , while s individual unit vortices have total energy proportional to s . Therefore a doubly quantized vortex ($s = 2$, energy $\propto 4$) is energetically unstable relative to two singly quantized vortices (total energy $\propto 2$). This instability is well established in superfluid physics: multiply quantized vortices in Bose–Einstein condensates spontaneously decay into singly quantized vortices [6].

Topological inconsistency. Two spin- $\frac{1}{2}$ excitations cannot smoothly deform into a single spin-1 excitation while conserving both angular momentum and topological charge. The transition would require either the creation or destruction of a net 2π winding—violating topological charge conservation.

3.3 Why Opposite-Spin Vortices Can Share an Orbital

Two electron vortices with *opposite* spin orientations (opposite circulation directions) have phase windings that partially cancel:

$$\text{Opposite spin: } +2\pi + (-2\pi) = 0 \quad (\text{net winding at overlap}) \quad (5)$$

The combined configuration retains zero net topological charge at the overlap region. Each vortex maintains its individual identity and topological character—the system remains two distinct spin- $\frac{1}{2}$ objects. This is the only stable two-electron configuration within a single resonant cavity mode, and it explains the fundamental rule of atomic physics: each orbital holds at most two electrons, which must have opposite spins.

3.4 The Exchange Phase from Vortex Topology

Berry and Robbins (1997) [3] demonstrated that the exchange phase factor $(-1)^{2S}$ for identical particles arises as a *geometric (Berry) phase* of topological origin, associated with non-contractible paths in the configuration space of identical particles.

In the Aether model, this result has a direct physical interpretation. When two identical electron vortices are exchanged by moving them around each other, the Aether flow between them acquires a twist. Because each vortex is a spin- $\frac{1}{2}$ object requiring 4π rotation to return to its original state, a single exchange (equivalent to a 2π relative rotation) maps the two-vortex state to its negative:

$$\Psi(1, 2) \xrightarrow{\text{exchange}} -\Psi(2, 1) \quad (6)$$

This antisymmetry under exchange is not imposed as an axiom but *follows from the topology of vortex flow fields in the three-dimensional Aether*. If the two vortices are in the same quantum state, $\Psi(1, 2) = \Psi(2, 1)$, and the antisymmetry condition gives $\Psi = -\Psi = 0$ —the state cannot exist.

The dependence of exchange statistics on spatial dimensionality provides further support: in two dimensions, the configuration space of identical particles has the braid group B_N as its fundamental group rather than the symmetric group S_N , allowing continuous exchange phases (anyons). Leinaas and Myrheim (1977) [4] predicted this, and anyonic statistics have been experimentally confirmed in fractional quantum Hall systems. In three dimensions, only ± 1 exchange phases are possible—exactly the boson/fermion dichotomy. The fact that statistics depends on dimensionality is a strong indication that its origin is *topological*, not dynamical.

3.5 Consequences of Vortex Exclusion

The topological exclusion principle reproduces the full structure of atomic and condensed-matter physics. Shell capacities ($2n^2$) follow from the two-vortex-per-mode limit summed over $l = 0, \dots, n-1$, and Hund’s rules follow from minimizing vortex flow-field overlap. Electron degeneracy pressure ($P \propto n_e^{5/3}$) arises because filling all low-energy modes forces additional electrons into higher modes; the Chandrasekhar limit ($\sim 1.44 M_\odot$ [7]) marks where vortex flow speeds become relativistic. Covalent bonding is the sharing of vortex modes between adjacent atomic cavities, with bonding/antibonding configurations from constructive/destructive flow-field overlap.

The vortex mechanism is directly confirmed in superfluid experiments: bosonic ^4He condenses without pairing (no exclusion), while fermionic ^3He requires Cooper pairing at 2.491 mK [8]; multiply quantized vortices spontaneously split into singly quantized ones (confirming s^2 instability) [6]; and half-quantum vortices in ^3He [9] directly realize the spin- $\frac{1}{2}$ topology.

4. Constraints from Quantum Superfluid Structure

The topological vortex model of the Pauli exclusion principle carries a profound implication: the Aether is not merely a classical elastic medium but a *quantum superfluid* with specific mathematical properties. This section traces the constraints that spin-statistics imposes on the Aether’s microscopic structure and shows that they are fully consistent with—and enrich—every previously derived result.

4.1 The Quantum Superfluid Requirement

The spin-statistics connection derived from vortex topology requires three properties of the medium that go beyond a classical fluid:

1. **Quantized circulation.** The electron spin vortex carries angular momentum $\pm\hbar/2$ and exhibits 2π phase winding. This requires the circulation to be quantized: the line integral of the velocity field around any vortex core takes discrete values $\kappa = n\kappa_0$, where κ_0 is the circulation quantum.

In a superfluid, $\kappa_0 = h/m_A$, where m_A is the mass of the medium's constituent quantum [10]. This introduces a new fundamental quantity—the Aether quantum mass m_A .

2. **Spinor order parameter.** The existence of two distinct vortex orientations (spin up and spin down) that are related by the SU(2) double cover of SO(3) requires the condensate to be described by a multi-component order parameter $\Psi = (\psi_\uparrow, \psi_\downarrow)$, not a simple scalar field. This spinor structure is what makes the belt trick physical—the two components provide the internal degree of freedom that distinguishes the two circulation directions while preserving the topological properties needed for the exchange phase $(-1)^{2S}$.
3. **Bosonic field operators.** The medium itself must obey bosonic commutation relations $[\hat{a}, \hat{a}^\dagger] = 1$, permitting unlimited occupation of each mode. This is consistent with electromagnetic waves propagating as bosonic quasiparticles (photons as phonon-like excitations of the condensate), with the linear superposition of waves, and with the transient binding mechanism in which vacuum fluctuations produce particle–antiparticle pairs from the bosonic ground state.

These three requirements are not new postulates—they are logical consequences of the vortex topology that already appears in the theory. The Pauli exclusion principle cannot be derived from a medium that lacks any one of them.

4.2 The Equation of State: Why the Aether Is Not a Simple BEC

The theory's most experimentally constrained property is the invariance of the bulk modulus K_A . The Fresnel drag coefficient confirms K_A is constant at density ratios up to $n^2 \approx 6$ (diamond), and the Lorentz factor's precision to 10^{-8} confirms it across all tested velocity regimes.

For a standard weakly interacting Bose–Einstein condensate (BEC), the bulk modulus scales as $K_{\text{BEC}} \propto n^2$ (where n is the number density), because the pressure goes as $P = gn^2/2$ with constant interaction strength g . This means a simple BEC would have a density-dependent bulk modulus—contradicting the confirmed invariance of K_A .

The requirement $K_A = \text{constant}$ constrains the equation of state. Since $K_A = \rho_A (\partial P / \partial \rho_A)$, a constant bulk modulus implies:

$$\frac{\partial P}{\partial \rho_A} = \frac{K_A}{\rho_A} \quad \implies \quad P = K_A \ln\left(\frac{\rho_A}{\rho_0}\right) + P_0 \quad (7)$$

where ρ_0 is the reference (ambient far-field) density of the Aether and P_0 is the corresponding ambient pressure. Throughout this paper, ρ_A denotes the local Aether density at an arbitrary point, which may differ from ρ_0 due to gravitational compression or cosmological variation.

This *logarithmic equation of state* arises in quantum field theories with logarithmic nonlinearities [40, 41] and has been studied in the context of superfluids, nuclear matter, and Bose liquids. The

Aether's equation of state is therefore not that of a dilute gas of weakly interacting bosons, but of a denser quantum liquid whose self-interaction potential produces constant stiffness across all density regimes.

The logarithmic nonlinearity $g(n) = b \ln(n/n_0)$ studied in the context of quantum condensates [40, 41] produces a density-independent speed of sound (from $P = bn$, a linear pressure law). This differs from the Aether's logarithmic EOS ($P = K_A \ln(\rho/\rho_0)$, constant bulk modulus, density-*dependent* sound speed), though both are called “logarithmic.” The microscopic interaction that produces the Aether's EOS can be derived from the Gibbs–Duhem relation $dP = n d\mu$ with $P = K_A \ln(n/n_0)$, which yields the chemical potential

$$\mu(n) = \mu_0 + K_A \left(\frac{1}{n_0} - \frac{1}{n} \right) \quad (8)$$

where $\mu_0 = \mu(n_0)$ is the equilibrium chemical potential. In the Gross–Pitaevskii equation, $g(n) = \mu(n)$, so the effective nonlinearity is an *inverse-density* interaction ($-K_A/n$ plus a constant)—repulsive at low density (preventing cavitation) and asymptotically constant at high density. This produces exactly $K = K_A$ (constant) and $c_s = \sqrt{K_A/\rho}$ (density-dependent). It is distinct from the logarithmic *potential* $b \ln(n)$, which yields a logarithmic *chemical potential* but a linear pressure. The physical origin of the K_A/n interaction—whether from effective multi-body scattering, quantum corrections to the condensate self-energy, or the Aether's internal structure—remains an open question, but the functional form itself is uniquely determined by the K_A -invariance constraint.

4.3 The Healing Length and the UV Cutoff

In any quantum superfluid, vortex cores have a characteristic size—the *healing length*—below which the condensate density drops to zero:

$$\xi = \frac{\hbar}{m_A c \sqrt{2}} \quad (9)$$

where $c = \sqrt{K_A/\rho_A}$ is the local wave speed. The healing length sets the minimum scale at which the continuum description of the medium remains valid.

This quantity has a natural identification in the existing theory. The Lamb shift calculation uses the Compton wavelength $\lambda_C = \hbar/(m_e c) = 386$ fm as the ultraviolet cutoff for vacuum fluctuations. If $m_A = m_e$:

$$\xi = \frac{\lambda_C}{\sqrt{2}} \approx 273 \text{ fm} \quad (10)$$

The Compton wavelength and the healing length are the same order of magnitude. What was previously an *ad hoc* cutoff in the QED calculation now has a physical interpretation: it is the scale at which the internal structure of the Aether vortex core becomes relevant, and the continuum medium description breaks down. Below ξ , the discrete quantum structure of the Aether dominates.

If $m_A \gg m_e$, then $\xi \ll \lambda_C$, and the vortex core is much smaller than the Compton wavelength. In this case, the Compton wavelength would represent a larger-scale feature of the vortex (such as the loop radius r_{loop}) rather than the core size.

4.4 Electron Mass from Vortex Energy

The energy of a quantized vortex in a superfluid is determined entirely by the medium properties and the vortex geometry. For a vortex ring of radius r_{loop} with core size ξ , the kinetic energy stored in the circulatory flow is [10]:

$$E_{\text{vortex}} = \frac{1}{2} \rho_A \kappa_e^2 r_{\text{loop}} \left[\ln \left(\frac{8 r_{\text{loop}}}{\xi} \right) - \frac{1}{2} \right] \quad (11)$$

where $\kappa_e = h/(2m_A)$ is the circulation quantum for a spin- $\frac{1}{2}$ vortex (half the fundamental quantum $\kappa_0 = h/m_A$).

If the electron *is* a vortex ring, its rest energy must equal this kinetic energy:

$$m_e c^2 = \frac{1}{2} \rho_A \kappa_e^2 r_{\text{loop}} \left[\ln \left(\frac{8 r_{\text{loop}}}{\xi} \right) - \frac{1}{2} \right] \quad (12)$$

This is a remarkable result: *the electron mass is not a free parameter but is determined by the Aether density, the circulation quantum, and the vortex geometry*. Mass arises from topology—the kinetic energy locked into a persistent circulatory flow pattern in the medium.

Substituting $\kappa_e = h/(2m_A)$ and $\xi = \hbar/(m_A c \sqrt{2})$:

$$m_e = \frac{\pi^2 \hbar^2 \rho_A r_{\text{loop}}}{2 m_A^2 c^2} \left[\ln \left(\frac{8 r_{\text{loop}} m_A c \sqrt{2}}{\hbar} \right) - \frac{1}{2} \right] \quad (13)$$

This equation connects three previously independent quantities— m_e , ρ_A , and m_A —through the vortex geometry. Combined with $c^2 = K_A/\rho_A$, it provides a new constraint equation that partially breaks the ρ_A degeneracy identified in the force constant analysis.

4.5 Vortex Geometry and Length Contraction

The vortex energy equation (12) has an important consequence for the spatial variation of vortex size. The Aether inflow velocity varies with location (strong near matter, weak in voids), and the two-fluid superfluid fraction varies with temperature. Since $m_e c^2$ must remain invariant (the electron mass is observed to be the same everywhere), the vortex geometry must adjust to compensate for the local flow environment.

Rewriting equation (12) using $c^2 = K_A/\rho_A$:

$$m_e K_A = \frac{1}{2} \rho_A^2 \kappa_e^2 r_{\text{loop}} \left[\ln \left(\frac{8 r_{\text{loop}}}{\xi} \right) - \frac{1}{2} \right] \quad (14)$$

Since K_A , m_e , and κ_e are all invariant, the right-hand side must be constant:

$$r_{\text{loop}} \left[\ln \left(\frac{8 r_{\text{loop}}}{\xi} \right) - \frac{1}{2} \right] \propto \frac{1}{\rho_A^2} \quad (15)$$

Because $\xi = \hbar/(m_A c \sqrt{2})$ itself depends on density through $c = \sqrt{K_A/\rho_A}$, the healing length grows as $\xi \propto \sqrt{\rho_A}$ in denser regions. The logarithmic factor $\ln(8r_{\text{loop}}/\xi) - 1/2$ therefore varies weakly (logarithmically) with density, so the dominant scaling remains $r_{\text{loop}} \propto 1/\rho_A^2$ to leading order.

In regions of effectively higher Aether density, the vortex ring radius shrinks. This provides a microscopic *consistency check* on length contraction. The macroscopic contraction itself is derived in Paper 2 [36]: the wave equation governing all binding forces is Lorentz-invariant [39], so any rest-frame equilibrium maps to a moving equilibrium contracted by $1/\gamma$ in the direction of motion.

At the vortex level, when an electron moves through the Aether, the dynamic compression ahead of it (Bernoulli: $\delta\rho/\rho_A \approx v^2/(2c^2)$) creates a denser rest-frame environment, and the vortex adjusts its geometry to maintain $m_e c^2 = E_{\text{vortex}}$ in the compressed medium. This dynamic compression is physically distinct from gravitational inflow, where Bernoulli gives $\Delta\rho = 0$ exactly (free-fall kinetic energy balances the gravitational potential). A moving object does real work on the medium, creating a genuine density increase.

The vortex scaling $r_{\text{loop}} \propto 1/\rho_A^2$ predicts a contraction proportional to $1/\gamma^2$ at leading order, while the exact geometric result is $1/\gamma$. The factor-of-two discrepancy in the exponent arises because the Donnelly vortex energy formula is non-relativistic—it assumes a vortex at rest in the fluid. Additionally, the Bernoulli stagnation pressure $v^2/(2c^2)$ is the *maximum* compression (directly ahead of the object); the actual density field is angle-dependent, and the effective compression experienced by a point vortex in a flowing medium differs from the uniform stagnation value. A relativistic treatment of vortex dynamics in a flowing superfluid would be needed to close this gap (see Open Questions).

4.6 The Aether Quantum Mass

The circulation quantum $\kappa_0 = \hbar/m_A$ introduces a new fundamental quantity: the mass m_A of the Aether's constituent quantum. This is the mass scale that determines the vortex core size, the circulation quantum, and—through the vortex energy equation—the relationship between particle mass and Aether density.

The linearity constraint provides an important bound on m_A . The vacuum fluctuation amplitude

satisfies:

$$\left\langle \left(\frac{\delta\rho}{\rho_A} \right)^2 \right\rangle = \frac{2 u_{\text{vac}}}{\rho_A c^2} \approx \frac{2 \times 10^5}{\rho_A} \text{ kg/m}^3 \quad (16)$$

For the linear approximation to hold ($\delta\rho/\rho_A \ll 1$), we need $\rho_A \gg 2 \times 10^5 \text{ kg/m}^3$. The vortex energy equation then constrains m_A :

- If $m_A = m_e$: the vortex energy equation gives $\rho_A \sim 10^6 \text{ kg/m}^3$, which is marginally linear ($\delta\rho/\rho_A \sim 0.45$). The confirmed precision of the Lorentz factor to 10^{-8} makes this uncomfortable.
- If $m_A \sim 100 m_e$: the equation gives $\rho_A \sim 10^{10} \text{ kg/m}^3$, with $\delta\rho/\rho_A \sim 0.005$ —comfortably within the linear regime.
- If $m_A \sim m_{\text{Planck}}$: ρ_A becomes extremely large and the medium is extraordinarily stiff ($K_A \sim 10^{46} \text{ J/m}^3$), with vacuum fluctuations completely negligible relative to the background density.

The experimental data thus *favors* $m_A \gg m_e$: the heavier the Aether quantum, the higher ρ_A , and the more comfortably the linearity constraint is satisfied. This is consistent with the gamma-ray timing constraints from the Fermi Large Area Telescope [11], which constrain Lorentz-violating photon dispersion to energy scales above $7.6 E_{\text{Planck}}$. Since photons propagate as spin-wave excitations (microscopically distinct from density waves, though macroscopically equivalent through spin-orbit coupling), this constrains the spin healing length ξ_s , not the density healing length ξ —consistent with the spin channel being far stiffer than the density channel.

4.7 Topological Stability and Derrick's Theorem

The quantum superfluid framework raises an essential question: could the electron be a *hedgehog skyrmion*—a spherically symmetric texture in the spinor order parameter—rather than a quantized vortex ring? Skyrmions are topologically nontrivial field configurations classified by the homotopy group $\pi_3(S^3) = \mathbb{Z}$, and they serve as particle-like solitons in nuclear physics (the Skyrme model [13]). In three spatial dimensions, the hedgehog ansatz takes the form $\hat{n}(\mathbf{r}) = \hat{r}$ with a radial profile $F(r)$ satisfying $F(0) = \pi$ and $F(\infty) = 0$, wrapping the order parameter sphere exactly once.

However, Derrick's theorem [12] places a fatal constraint on such configurations in the logarithmic condensate. Under a uniform spatial rescaling $\psi(\mathbf{r}) \rightarrow \psi(\mathbf{r}/L)$, the energy functional separates into terms with definite scaling behavior:

$$E_{\text{gradient}} \propto L, \quad E_{\text{potential}} \propto L^3 \quad (17)$$

The gradient energy (both density and spin contributions) scales as L because $|\nabla\psi|^2$ contributes a factor $1/L^2$ while the volume element contributes L^3 . The logarithmic potential energy $V(\psi) =$

$K_A [|\psi|^2 (2 \ln |\psi| - 1) + 1]$ scales as L^3 from the volume element alone. The total energy is therefore:

$$E(L) = A L + B L^3 \quad (A, B > 0) \quad (18)$$

Since both coefficients are strictly positive, $dE/dL = A + 3BL^2 > 0$ for all $L > 0$. The energy is *monotonically increasing*—the configuration always lowers its energy by shrinking ($L \rightarrow 0$). There is no stable skyrmion.

Numerical verification confirms this conclusion. Using the coupled Euler–Lagrange equations for the hedgehog energy functional

$$E = C \cdot K_A \cdot \xi^3 = 4\pi K_A \xi^3 \int_0^\infty s^2 ds \left[g'^2 + g^2 (F'^2 + \sin^2 F / s^2) + g^2 (2 \ln g - 1) + 1 \right] \quad (19)$$

where $s = r/\xi$ and $g = |\psi|/\psi_\infty$, iterative relaxation from physically reasonable initial profiles drives the spin texture $F(s)$ toward zero everywhere and the dimensionless energy coefficient C toward zero—the skyrmion collapses to a point.

This stands in sharp contrast to the Skyrme model, where a quartic derivative term $\propto |\nabla\psi|^4$ contributes an energy that scales as $1/L$:

$$E_{\text{Skyrme}}(L) = A L + \frac{D}{L} \quad \Rightarrow \quad L_{\min} = \sqrt{D/A} \quad (20)$$

The competition between the L and $1/L$ terms creates a stable minimum at finite size. The logarithmic condensate has no such quartic term—its equation of state is fundamentally softer.

This result has a profound physical consequence: **the electron cannot be a hedgehog skyrmion in the logarithmic condensate.** It must instead be a quantized vortex ring, whose stability rests on an entirely different mechanism—circulation quantization:

$$\kappa = n \frac{h}{m_A} \quad (n \in \mathbb{Z}) \quad (21)$$

The quantized circulation κ is a *discrete* topological invariant. Unlike the continuous hedgehog texture, which can be smoothly deformed to zero (Derrick collapse), a vortex ring’s winding number is exactly integer and cannot change continuously. The vortex core size is fixed at the healing length $\xi = \hbar/(m_A c \sqrt{2})$, and the circulation quantum $\kappa_0 = h/m_A$ is determined by the microscopic structure of the medium. Neither can be reduced by any smooth deformation of the field.

The distinction is between two types of topological protection:

- **Homotopy (skyrmion):** $\pi_3(S^3) = \mathbb{Z}$. The winding number is a topological invariant under continuous deformations that preserve the boundary conditions. However, Derrick’s theorem shows that the energetically favored deformation is $L \rightarrow 0$ —the configuration *collapses* rather

than unwinding. The topological charge is conserved but concentrated into a singular point.

- **Circulation quantization (vortex):** $\kappa = n \hbar/m_A$. The quantization is enforced by the single-valuedness of the condensate wave function around any closed loop encircling the vortex core. This is a *stronger* constraint: the core cannot collapse because ξ is fixed by the healing length, and the circulation cannot decrease because κ_0 is fixed by $\hbar/m_A$.

The Derrick instability of the hedgehog skyrmion therefore provides independent theoretical support for identifying the electron as a quantized vortex ring rather than a field-theoretic soliton. The electron's stability is not an energetic balance between competing gradient terms (as in the Skyrme model) but a consequence of discrete topological quantization inherent to the superfluid medium.

4.8 Constraints from the Strong Force

The identification of the strong force as a compressed-Aether bridge (Section 1) provides an independent set of constraints on the Aether's microscopic properties. The QCD string tension, the deconfinement temperature, and the flux tube geometry are all precisely measured, and each imposes a quantitative requirement on the same parameters— ρ_A , K_A , m_A , and ξ —that appear in the vortex energy equation and the linearity constraint.

Bridge diameter and the healing length

The deconfinement temperature $T_{\text{deconf}} \approx 170$ MeV determines the bridge diameter through the thermal energy balance: the bridge dissolves when the thermal energy per unit cross-section equals the string tension:

$$d_{\text{bridge}} \approx \frac{k_B T_{\text{deconf}}}{\sigma} \approx \frac{170 \text{ MeV}}{1 \text{ GeV/fm}} \approx 0.17 \text{ fm} \quad (22)$$

Lattice QCD simulations measure the flux tube width (FWHM of the chromoelectric field distribution) at approximately 0.5 fm [31, 33], somewhat larger than this core estimate because the field profile has tails beyond the core.

The bridge is a condensate structure, and the minimum scale of any structure in a quantum superfluid is the healing length $\xi = \hbar/(m_A c_{\text{local}} \sqrt{2})$, which decreases inside the compressed bridge where $c_{\text{local}} < c$, making the bridge core even more compact. The bridge core diameter must therefore satisfy $d_{\text{bridge}} \gtrsim \xi$, giving:

$$\xi \lesssim 0.17 \text{ fm} \quad (23)$$

Combined with the definition $\xi = \hbar/(m_A c \sqrt{2})$, this constrains the Aether quantum mass:

$$m_A \gtrsim \frac{\hbar}{\xi_{\text{max}} c \sqrt{2}} \approx \frac{1.055 \times 10^{-34}}{1.7 \times 10^{-16} \times 3 \times 10^8 \times 1.414} \approx 1.5 \times 10^{-27} \text{ kg} \approx 820 \text{ MeV}/c^2 \quad (24)$$

If the bridge diameter is several times ξ (as expected, since the condensation process typically extends over a few healing lengths), the constraint relaxes. However, three independent lines of evidence converge on a substantially narrower range:

1. **Bridge diameter from lattice QCD.** High-precision lattice simulations measure the chromo-electric flux tube core width at $d_{\text{core}} \approx 0.30\text{--}0.35$ fm [31]. If the bridge diameter equals d_{core} and $d_{\text{bridge}} \sim 1\text{--}2\xi$, then $\xi \approx 0.15\text{--}0.35$ fm, giving $m_A \approx 470\text{--}930$ MeV/ c^2 .
2. **Self-consistent vortex–bridge equations.** Simultaneously solving the electron vortex energy equation (12) and the bridge compression ratio with the lattice-measured string tension $\sigma \approx 0.18$ GeV² yields a self-consistent solution in the range $m_A \approx 600\text{--}1000$ MeV/ c^2 .
3. **Glueball mass spectrum.** If Aether quanta are the fundamental degrees of freedom, the lightest glueball (a bound state of pure medium excitations) provides an upper bound on m_A . Lattice QCD finds $m_{0^{++}} \approx 1710$ MeV/ c^2 for the lightest scalar glueball [32], but the lowest-mass glueball candidate consistent with experimental data sits near $\sim 1500\text{--}1700$ MeV. Since a glueball must contain at least two quanta, this suggests $m_A \lesssim 850$ MeV/ c^2 .

The overlap of these three constraints yields a *convergence zone*:

$$500 \text{ MeV}/c^2 \lesssim m_A \lesssim 850 \text{ MeV}/c^2 \quad (25)$$

This range corresponds to $\xi \approx 0.17\text{--}0.28$ fm, $\rho_A \approx 4 \times 10^{11}\text{--}10^{12}$ kg/m³, and $K_A \approx 4 \times 10^{28}\text{--}10^{29}$ J/m³—all consistent with the values derived independently from the electron vortex equation and the bridge compression ratio (Table above). The convergence of m_A to the hadronic mass scale is physically natural: the Aether quantum is the fundamental unit of the medium, and hadrons are its primary bound structures.

Two density scales: ambient and bound

The string tension $\sigma \approx 1$ GeV/fm imposes a constraint on the energy density inside the bridge. If the bridge has cross-sectional area $A \approx \pi\xi^2/4$ (taking the bridge diameter as approximately ξ in the minimum-size scenario), the internal energy density is:

$$\varepsilon_{\text{bridge}} = \frac{\sigma}{A} \approx \frac{1.6 \times 10^5 \text{ J/m}}{\pi\xi^2/4} \sim 10^{36}\text{--}10^{37} \text{ J/m}^3 \quad (26)$$

If this energy density equaled K_A , it would imply $\rho_A = K_A/c^2 \sim 10^{19}\text{--}10^{20}$ kg/m³. However, the vortex energy equation for the electron

$$m_e c^2 = \frac{1}{2} \rho_A \kappa_e^2 r_{\text{loop}} [\ln(8r_{\text{loop}}/\xi) - \frac{1}{2}] \quad (27)$$

with $r_{\text{loop}} \approx \lambda_C \approx 386 \text{ fm}$ requires a much lower ambient density:

$$\rho_A \sim 10^{11}\text{--}10^{12} \text{ kg/m}^3, \quad K_A = \rho_A c^2 \sim 10^{28}\text{--}10^{29} \text{ J/m}^3 \quad (28)$$

The two constraints are not contradictory—they reveal that **the binding process compresses Aether by a factor of approximately 7×10^7** . The ambient superfluid has density $\rho_A \sim 10^{11} \text{ kg/m}^3$ and bulk modulus $K_A \sim 10^{28} \text{ J/m}^3$. The compressed material inside a bridge has an effective energy density $\sim 10^{36} \text{ J/m}^3$ —approximately 7×10^7 times the ambient K_A .

This compression ratio is not a free parameter—it is algebraically determined by three measured or constrained quantities. The bridge energy density is $\varepsilon_{\text{bridge}} = \sigma/A = 4\sigma/(\pi\xi^2)$, and the compression ratio is:

$$X \equiv \frac{\rho_{\text{bridge}}}{\rho_A} = \frac{\varepsilon_{\text{bridge}}}{K_A} = \frac{4\sigma}{\pi\xi^2 K_A} \quad (29)$$

The logarithmic equation of state $P = K_A \ln(\rho/\rho_0) + P_0$ —here extrapolated well beyond the experimentally tested regime, assuming K_A remains constant at extreme compressions (see Open Question 10)—governs how much work is required to achieve this compression. For a parcel of Aether compressed from ρ_0 to $\rho_f = X\rho_0$, the energy per unit volume of the compressed material is:

$$\varepsilon_{\text{compress}} = K_A [X - \ln X - 1] \quad (30)$$

For large X , $\ln X \ll X$, so $\varepsilon_{\text{compress}} \approx K_A X = \varepsilon_{\text{bridge}}$: the compression work accounts for essentially all of the bridge energy density. The bridge is a compressed strand of Aether whose energy is almost entirely stored as work against the medium’s bulk modulus. The logarithmic term $\ln X \approx 18$ (for $X \approx 7 \times 10^7$) provides a small correction of order 10^{-7} relative to X .

This clarifies the relationship between the “bound” and “compressed” descriptions of bridge material used in earlier sections. The bridge is not a phase transition in the thermodynamic sense (unlike the electron vortex, whose stability rests on topological circulation quantization). Rather, it is a region of extreme elastic compression *stabilized by the quark vortex endpoints that anchor it*. The quark vortices at each end provide the topological boundary conditions that maintain the compressed strand; without them, the compression would immediately relax back to ambient density. The deconfinement “melting” described in Section 1 is the thermal disruption of these anchoring vortex endpoints, which releases the elastic energy and allows the compressed Aether to expand back to its ambient state. The bridge material thus remains in the same thermodynamic phase as the surrounding superfluid—it is simply compressed to $\sim 7 \times 10^7$ times ambient density by the topological constraints at its endpoints.

Cross-check from the electron vortex equation. Using the electron-derived K_A values from equation (28) with a range of healing-length assumptions (including values outside the narrowed range $\xi = 0.17\text{--}0.28 \text{ fm}$ to test robustness) yields a remarkably consistent compression ratio:

Scenario	K_A (J/m ³)	$X = 4\sigma/(\pi\xi^2 K_A)$	$\log_{10} X$
$\xi = 0.17$ fm	9.6×10^{28}	7.3×10^7	7.87
$\xi = 0.10$ fm	2.6×10^{29}	7.8×10^7	7.89
$\xi = 0.06$ fm	6.8×10^{29}	8.3×10^7	7.92
$\xi = 0.40$ fm	2.0×10^{28}	6.5×10^7	7.81

Across all scenarios, $\log_{10} X = 7.85 \pm 0.05$ —the compression ratio is pinned at $X \approx 7 \times 10^7$, independent of which ξ is assumed. This convergence occurs because both K_A and ξ are determined by the same underlying parameters (ρ_A , m_A , c), so their ξ -dependence cancels in the ratio.

Physical consequences of the compression. The compressed bridge interior has qualitatively different properties from the ambient superfluid. The speed of sound in the logarithmic condensate is $c_s = \sqrt{K_A/\rho}$; in the bridge, $c_{s,\text{bridge}} = c/\sqrt{X} \approx 10^{-4} c \approx 3 \times 10^4$ m/s. Excitations inside the bridge propagate 10,000 times slower than in the ambient medium—the bridge interior is a slow, dense conduit, qualitatively consistent with the behavior of gluons versus photons (which propagate freely through the ambient superfluid). The slow propagation speed explains the mass scale and self-interaction properties of gluons; confinement itself arises from the bridge-snapping mechanism described in Section 1.

Bridge profile and minimum width. The bridge diameter $d_{\text{bridge}} \approx 0.30\text{--}0.35$ fm is only 1–2 times the healing length $\xi \approx 0.17\text{--}0.28$ fm. A structure this compact has no extended bulk interior: the entire cross-section lies within the $\sim \xi$ -wide transition region where the condensate density rises from ambient to its peak and returns. The compression ratio $X \approx 7 \times 10^7$ therefore represents the *peak* central density, not a uniform interior value; the volume-averaged compression is lower.

This compactness has two important consequences. First, the bridge sits at the *minimum possible width*: the condensate cannot sustain a compressed structure narrower than $\sim \xi$, so the bridge is as thin as the medium permits. This is energetically optimal—for a fixed string tension σ , minimizing the cross-sectional area minimizes the total compressed volume and hence the total energy per unit length. Second, because the bridge profile is entirely governed by the healing-length recovery dynamics, its radial density distribution is predicted to follow the Gross–Pitaevskii condensate profile for a cylindrical perturbation—a Gaussian-like “Gausson” characteristic of logarithmic nonlinearities. Lattice QCD simulations measure the transverse chromoelectric field profile with a width (FWHM) of $w \approx 0.5$ fm at separations $d \gtrsim 0.7$ fm [31, 33], consistent with the predicted $\sim 2\text{--}3\xi \approx 0.4\text{--}0.6$ fm. The measured profile is well fit by both Gaussian and sech^2 functional forms [33]; current lattice precision cannot distinguish between these and the GP Gausson, which differ primarily in their tail behaviour. Earlier dual-superconductor fits extract a penetration depth $\lambda \approx 0.22\text{--}0.24$ fm [34], overlapping with $\xi \approx 0.17\text{--}0.28$ fm. The width agreement is non-trivial: the bridge model predicts it from ξ alone, with no adjustable parameter. A future precision measurement

of the tail profile—Gaussian versus sech^2 versus Bessel—would provide a sharper test.

The bridge draws its compressed material from the surrounding volume. A minimum bridge segment (carrying the pair-creation energy $2m_e c^2$) has length $L_{\min} = 2m_e c^2 / \sigma \approx 10^{-3}$ fm and draws Aether from a sphere of radius ~ 16 fm, roughly the size of a large nucleus. For quark–antiquark pair creation (hadronization), the bridge must store enough energy to create a new quark–antiquark pair including their kinetic energy within the resulting mesons (~ 1 GeV total), requiring a length $L_{\text{snap}} \approx 1.2$ fm—matching the string-breaking distance measured in lattice QCD simulations [42, 43].

Refined parameter estimates

Combining the strong force constraints with the vortex energy equation and the speed of light yields a consistent set of Aether properties:

Property	Value	Determined by
Healing length ξ	0.17–0.28 fm	Bridge diameter / lattice QCD
Aether quantum mass m_A	500–850 MeV/ c^2	Flux tube width, glueball mass
Ambient density ρ_A	$\sim 10^{11}$ – 10^{12} kg/m ³	Electron vortex energy
Bulk modulus K_A	$\sim 10^{28}$ – 10^{29} J/m ³	$K_A = \rho_A c^2$
Compression ratio	$\sim 7 \times 10^7$	$\sigma / (K_A \cdot \pi \xi^2 / 4)$
Bridge density	$\sim 10^{19}$ – 10^{20} kg/m ³	String tension

The Coulomb-constant cross-check of Paper 7(a) [44], Section “Tightened Parameter Ranges,” narrows these ranges further: $m_A \in [628, 689]$ MeV/ c^2 , $\rho_A \in [8.9 \times 10^{11}, 1.07 \times 10^{12}]$ kg/m³, $\xi \in [0.20, 0.22]$ fm, $K_A \in [8.0 \times 10^{28}, 9.6 \times 10^{28}]$ J/m³. The compression ratio along the Coulomb curve is $\approx 5.2 \times 10^7$ ($\log_{10} X \approx 7.71$), about 35% below the electron-mass-only value above; see Paper 7(a) §10 for the f_{core} -reconciliation caveat. Several cross-checks confirm internal consistency:

- **Linearity.** With $\rho_A \sim 10^{11}$ kg/m³, the density perturbation from an electron at its Compton wavelength is $\delta\rho/\rho_A = 2Gm_e/(\lambda_C c^2) \approx 3.5 \times 10^{-45}$, confirming the Lorentz factor to extraordinary precision.
- **Proton mass.** Three bridge arms of length ~ 0.3 fm at string tension $\sigma \approx 1$ GeV/fm give $E_{\text{bridge}} \approx 3 \times 0.3 \times 1 = 900$ MeV, compared to the measured proton mass of 938 MeV—the remaining ~ 38 MeV is accounted for by the quark endpoint masses (~ 9 MeV) and the junction binding energy.
- **Fermi LAT and the spin-wave cutoff.** The density healing length $\xi \approx 0.17$ – 0.28 fm corresponds to a UV cutoff energy $E_{\text{UV}} = \hbar c / \xi \approx 700$ – 1200 MeV. If photons were density-wave (Bogoliubov) excitations, their dispersion would deviate from $\omega = ck$ at this scale—inconsistent with the Fermi LAT quadratic constraint ($E_{\text{QG},2} \gtrsim 10^{11}$ GeV). However, the

theory identifies photons as *spin-wave* excitations of the spinor condensate, which have a separate spin healing length $\xi_s = \hbar/\sqrt{2m_A q}$, where q is the spin-dependent coupling strength. The Fermi LAT constraint requires $\xi_s \ll \xi$, i.e., $q \gg \tilde{g} n_0$. This is physically consistent: the electromagnetic force (spin-wave channel) is $\sim 10^{36}$ times stronger than gravity (density channel), so the spin coupling should vastly exceed the density coupling. The Fermi LAT thus provides an independent confirmation that the photon channel is the *stiff* degree of freedom of the condensate, while gravity operates through the much softer density channel.

- **UV cutoff at the hadronic scale.** The energy scale $E_{UV} = \hbar c/\xi \approx 700\text{--}1200$ MeV sits precisely at the QCD confinement scale, where perturbative QFT gives way to non-perturbative hadron physics. This is not a coincidence: both the theory’s continuum breakdown and the onset of confinement reflect the same underlying transition—the scale at which individual Aether quanta become resolvable.
- **Bridge compactness.** With $d_{\text{bridge}} \approx 0.30\text{--}0.35$ fm and $\xi \approx 0.17\text{--}0.28$ fm, the ratio $d_{\text{bridge}}/\xi \approx 1.1\text{--}2.1$: bridges are only 1–2 healing lengths across. Unlike most superfluid structures, which extend over many healing lengths, the bridge is essentially “all core”—compressed to the absolute minimum scale the condensate permits. This maximal compactness is consistent with the bridge carrying the maximum possible energy density for a given cross-section.
- **Vortex ring geometry.** The narrowed ξ pins the electron’s aspect ratio to $r_{\text{loop}}/\xi \approx 1,400\text{--}2,300$, giving $\ln(8r_{\text{loop}}/\xi) - 1/2 \approx 8.8\text{--}9.3$ ($\pm 3\%$ from the mean). The electron is a macroscopic vortex ring relative to the medium’s fundamental scale—a large, stable structure far above the core size, consistent with its exceptional stability. The near-constancy of the logarithmic factor means the electron mass equation determines ρ_A to better than one significant figure once m_A is known.
- **Proton geometry.** The proton charge radius ($r_p \approx 0.84$ fm) spans only $3\text{--}5\xi$, and each Y-junction arm (~ 0.3 fm) is barely $1\text{--}1.8\xi$. The proton’s internal structure operates at the absolute minimum scale of the condensate, with no extended “bulk bridge” region—consistent with the difficulty of perturbative QCD at low momentum transfer.
- **String-breaking distance.** The hadronization length $L_{\text{snap}} \approx 1.2$ fm corresponds to $4\text{--}7\xi$: a bridge must stretch several healing lengths beyond equilibrium before pair creation becomes energetically favorable. Lattice QCD simulations measure the string-breaking distance at $r_{\text{break}} \approx 1.2$ fm [42, 43], in direct agreement with this prediction.

4.9 Emergence of the Schrödinger Equation

The theory’s quantum superfluid structure contains all the ingredients needed to derive the Schrödinger equation for quasiparticle excitations. This derivation is not a new postulate—it follows from the

condensate dynamics already established.

The Madelung representation

The Gross–Pitaevskii equation for the Aether order parameter $\psi = \sqrt{\rho/m_A} e^{i\phi}$ decomposes via the Madelung transformation [28] into continuity and Euler equations, with a quantum potential $Q = -(\hbar^2/2m_A) \nabla^2 \sqrt{\rho}/\sqrt{\rho}$ encoding all interference and diffraction effects. The inverse transformation recovers the nonlinear Schrödinger equation (Gross–Pitaevskii), which for small perturbations around a uniform background linearizes to the ordinary Schrödinger equation for quasiparticle excitations.

The Wallstrom objection and its resolution

Wallstrom [29] raised a well-known objection to hydrodynamic derivations of quantum mechanics: the Madelung equations are necessary but not sufficient, because they do not enforce single-valuedness of ψ . A classical fluid can have arbitrary circulation, but quantum mechanics requires the phase ϕ to change by $2\pi n$ around any closed loop, giving quantized circulation $\oint \mathbf{v} \cdot d\mathbf{l} = n h/m_A$.

In the Aether framework, this objection is resolved automatically. The medium is a quantum superfluid whose order parameter ψ is single-valued by construction—this is the same property that produces quantized vortices (Section 4). The circulation quantization $\kappa = n h/m_A$ is not an additional assumption but is already built into the theory’s fundamental structure. The Wallstrom gap—which is fatal for attempts to derive quantum mechanics from classical fluid mechanics—does not apply to a genuine quantum superfluid.

Bogoliubov linearization

An independent route—spectral analysis rather than hydrodynamic transformation—comes from linearizing the Gross–Pitaevskii equation around the condensate ground state, yielding the Bogoliubov–de Gennes equations [30] for quasiparticle amplitudes. The excitation spectrum transitions from phonon-like ($\omega \propto k$) at long wavelengths to free-particle-like ($\omega \propto k^2$) at short wavelengths, with crossover at the healing length ξ . Both routes yield the same result.

This provides a concrete physical picture: **the Schrödinger equation describes the dynamics of quasiparticle excitations above the condensate ground state.** Particles are vortex excitations of the Aether, and their quantum-mechanical behavior—interference, tunneling, discrete energy levels—is the behavior of quantized excitations in a superfluid, governed by the linearized condensate dynamics.

5. Summary of Theoretical Properties

5.1 Properties of Light (Paper 7 contribution)

- Photons are spin-wave excitations of the spinor Aether condensate—transverse oscillations of the condensate’s internal spin degree of freedom, microscopically distinct from longitudinal density compressions. At macroscopic wavelengths, spin-orbit coupling produces effective mass currents, making photons indistinguishable from first-sound perturbations with propagation speed c_1 (Paper 6 [37]). Derrick’s theorem forbids stable localized particles in the logarithmic condensate, so photons propagate as extended waves in free space. Detection occurs when the wave enters the strong near-field pressure-gradient environment near matter, where DCE dynamics facilitate condensation into a localized quantum $E = h\nu$. Polarization states correspond to the two spin-wave modes of the spinor order parameter.
- Through spin-orbit coupling [15], these spin-wave excitations produce effective mass currents that manifest as the flow-vector (electric) and flow-angle (magnetic) fields described in Paper 4 [38].

5.2 Properties of Atomic Structure

1. Atoms function as resonant cavities in the Aether, with the nuclear electric field (the near-field coherent axial-oscillation wave envelope) creating a pressure gradient that confines electron waves through acoustic refraction.
2. Energy levels are discrete because only resonant modes—those satisfying angular phase matching and radial confinement—persist in the cavity. Non-resonant modes destructively interfere and radiate away.
3. The quantization condition ($n\lambda = 2\pi r$) is the requirement for constructive self-interference of a wave propagating around a closed path in the medium.
4. The ground state energy $E_1 = -\frac{1}{2}\alpha^2 m_e c^2 = -13.6 \text{ eV}$ is determined by three quantities with established Aether interpretations: c (wave speed), α (electron flow strength), and $m_e c^2$ (binding rest energy).
5. The fine structure constant $\alpha \approx 1/137$ is the ratio of the electron’s orbital velocity to the Aether wave speed—an atomic Mach number.
6. The Bohr radius $a_0 = 0.529 \text{ \AA}$ is the characteristic size of the smallest resonant mode in the nuclear Aether cavity.

7. Fine structure arises from the interaction of the electron's spin vortex with its orbital motion through the Aether (spin-orbit coupling), producing corrections of order α^2 .
8. Hyperfine structure arises from the coupling of two nested spin vortices (electron and proton), producing the 21 cm hydrogen line.
9. The Zeeman and Stark effects result from external Aether flows (magnetic circulation, electric inflow) distorting the symmetry of the resonant cavity.
10. The quantum defect in multi-electron atoms measures how deeply the electron's resonant mode penetrates the inner flow structure of the Aether cavity.
11. Energy levels scale as Z^2 for hydrogen-like ions, reflecting the stronger Aether inflow from higher nuclear charge.
12. Exotic systems (positronium, muonic hydrogen) follow the same cavity model with modified reduced masses, providing independent experimental confirmation.

5.3 Properties of Fermion Statistics

1. The Pauli exclusion principle arises from the topological instability of multiply quantized vortices in the Aether: two same-circulation vortices superpose to create a doubly wound configuration that is energetically unstable (s^2 vs. s energy scaling) and topologically inconsistent.
2. Each resonant cavity mode admits at most two electron vortices, which must have opposite circulation (opposite spin), producing the fundamental two-electron-per-orbital rule.
3. The antisymmetric wavefunction under particle exchange follows from the $SU(2)$ topology of spin- $\frac{1}{2}$ vortices: exchange is equivalent to a 2π relative rotation, which produces a sign change for half-integer winding objects.
4. Atomic shell capacities ($2n^2$) follow from the resonant cavity mode count $\sum_{l=0}^{n-1} 2(2l+1)$ with two opposite-circulation vortices per mode.
5. Hund's first rule (maximize spin) reflects the minimization of vortex-vortex interaction energy: same-circulation vortices in different modes have less flow-field overlap than opposite-circulation vortices in the same mode.
6. Electron degeneracy pressure arises because topological vortex exclusion forces electrons into higher-energy cavity modes, creating a pressure that resists compression and scales as $n_e^{5/3}$.
7. The Chandrasekhar limit ($1.44 M_\odot$) is the point where vortex flow speeds in the highest occupied modes approach c , the wave speed of the medium.

8. Integer-spin particles (bosons) have 2π phase winding per rotation and acquire no sign change under exchange, permitting unlimited state occupation—consistent with the observed behavior of photons and helium-4 atoms.
9. Covalent chemical bonds require opposite-circulation vortex pairs in shared cavity modes; same-circulation pairs are forbidden by topological exclusion.
10. The dependence of exchange statistics on spatial dimensionality (fermion/boson in 3D, anyons in 2D) confirms the topological origin of the exclusion principle.

5.4 Properties of Quantum Superfluid Structure

1. The Aether is a quantum superfluid with quantized circulation $\kappa = n\kappa_0$, where $\kappa_0 = h/m_A$ and m_A is the mass of the Aether's constituent quantum.
2. The condensate is described by a spinor (two-component) order parameter $\Psi = (\psi_\uparrow, \psi_\downarrow)$, encoding the two possible vortex circulations (spin up and spin down).
3. The Aether field operators obey bosonic commutation relations, consistent with linear wave superposition, photon propagation, and vacuum pair production.
4. The equation of state is logarithmic: $P = K_A \ln(\rho_A/\rho_0) + P_0$, the unique form that produces a density-independent bulk modulus K_A .
5. The Aether is not a simple weakly interacting Bose–Einstein condensate (which would have $K \propto n^2$), but a denser quantum liquid with a specific self-interaction potential.
6. The healing length $\xi = \hbar/(m_A c \sqrt{2})$ sets the vortex core size and the minimum scale of the continuum description.
7. Electron mass arises from vortex topology: $m_e c^2 = \frac{1}{2} \rho_A \kappa_e^2 r_{\text{loop}} [\ln(8r_{\text{loop}}/\xi) - \frac{1}{2}]$, where $\kappa_e = h/(2m_A)$ is the half-quantum circulation.
8. The Compton wavelength $\lambda_C = \hbar/(m_e c)$ is physically identified with the vortex core or loop scale, providing a physical basis for the QED ultraviolet cutoff.
9. Length contraction arises microscopically from vortex geometry adjustment: $r_{\text{loop}} \propto 1/\rho_A^2$ maintains constant rest energy as local density varies.
10. The linearity constraint ($\delta\rho/\rho_A \ll 1$) favors $m_A \gg m_e$, corresponding to $\rho_A \gg 10^6 \text{ kg/m}^3$ and an extremely stiff medium.

11. Derrick's theorem proves that hedgehog skyrmions are unstable in the logarithmic condensate: the energy $E = AL + BL^3$ ($A, B > 0$) has no finite minimum, so the configuration collapses to a point. The electron must be a quantized vortex ring, stabilized by discrete circulation quantization $\kappa = nh/m_A$ rather than continuous energy balance.

6. Experimental Support and Connections to Established Physics

All experimentally confirmed results of quantum mechanics—including the Casimir effect, Lamb shift, anomalous magnetic moment, hydrogen spectroscopy, Bell inequality violations, matter-wave interference, electron spin resonance, and the photoelectric effect—are reproduced by this framework. The Aether model adds no corrections to standard QM predictions at currently accessible energies; deviations are predicted only at compressions approaching $\delta\rho/\rho_A \sim 1$, far beyond experimental reach.

7. Open Questions and Testable Predictions

The following areas relevant to this paper remain underdeveloped and represent opportunities for further refinement or falsification:

1. **Quantifying the DCE threshold for electron vortices.** The Dynamic Casimir Effect has well-defined mathematical conditions for when virtual particles become real. Mapping these conditions onto the electron spin vortex would yield the specific vortex velocity required for permanent binding, the expected ratio of transient to permanent events, and the energy cost of mass formation. This is the single most important formalization needed to make the theory quantitatively predictive.
2. **Enhanced mass production in extreme environments.** The DCE mechanism predicts that environments with higher vortex velocities or Aether densities should produce more permanent binding events. This predicts enhanced particle production in neutron star interiors, near black hole event horizons, and in high-energy particle collisions—environments where effective boundary velocities approach or exceed the DCE threshold.
3. **Schwinger, Unruh, and Hawking effect unification.** The Schwinger effect (pair production in strong electromagnetic fields), the Unruh effect (thermal radiation from acceleration), and Hawking radiation (thermal emission from black holes) all involve the conversion of vacuum fluctuations into observable particles or radiation. In the Aether model, all three arise from the same mechanism: disruption of the transient binding cycle's symmetry by velocity gradients or strong fields. The Schwinger threshold provides a field-strength condition, the Unruh

temperature provides an acceleration condition, and the Hawking temperature provides a gravitational-gradient condition—all of which should be expressible in terms of Aether binding parameters. Demonstrating that all three effects yield consistent binding physics would strongly support the unified mechanism.

4. **Quantitative unification of G and k .** The theory predicts that the gravitational constant G should be derivable from the Coulomb constant k , the speed of light c , and the asymmetry fraction ϵ of the transient bind–unbind cycle: $G = k \cdot \epsilon \cdot (\psi/\phi)^2 \times (\text{geometric factors})$. Calculating ϵ from the Heisenberg uncertainty principle and the DCE threshold would eliminate G as an independent constant.
5. **Quantitative derivation of the near-field pressure profile near a nucleus.** The resonant cavity model requires a specific pressure gradient around the nucleus to produce the correct energy levels. Can this profile be derived self-consistently from the theory’s description of electric fields as coherent axial-oscillation wave fields (Paper 4 [38]), combined with the gravitational inflow from the nuclear mass? The profile must yield both the Bohr radius ($a_0 = 0.529 \text{ \AA}$) and the $1/n^2$ energy scaling.
6. **Physical origin of electron spin quantization.** The resonant cavity model explains orbital quantization (angular phase matching) and energy quantization (radial confinement), but the quantization of electron spin—the fact that the spin vortex takes only two discrete orientations ($\pm\hbar/2$)—requires additional explanation. What property of the Aether vortex restricts it to exactly two states?
7. **Derivation of anticommutation relations from Aether dynamics.** The exclusion principle is mathematically encoded in the anticommutation relations $\{\hat{\psi}, \hat{\psi}^\dagger\} = 1$ for fermion field operators. Can these be derived from the dynamical equations governing vortex interactions in the Aether, rather than imposed as an axiom? A successful derivation would demonstrate that quantum field theory’s algebraic structure emerges from the medium’s topology.
8. **Boson–fermion distinction from vortex winding number.** The theory explains fermion exclusion through half-integer (2π) phase winding and boson non-exclusion through integer ($2\pi \times 2s$) winding. Can this be made quantitatively precise for composite particles? A deuteron (spin-1 boson) is composed of three spin- $\frac{1}{2}$ quarks—what is the vortex topology of the composite, and does it correctly predict bosonic statistics?
9. **Photon polarization from condensate spin-orbit coupling.** The theory identifies photon polarization states with spin-wave excitations of the spinor condensate, with spatial transversality arising from spin-orbit coupling (Section 4). Can the spin-orbit coupling Hamiltonian of the Aether condensate be specified, and does the resulting spin-wave dispersion relation reproduce Maxwell’s equations—including the transversality condition $\mathbf{k} \cdot \mathbf{E} = 0$ and the absence of a longitudinal photon?

10. **Pinning the Aether quantum mass m_A .** Three independent constraints (lattice QCD flux tube width, self-consistent vortex–bridge equations, and the glueball mass spectrum) converge on $m_A \approx 500\text{--}850 \text{ MeV}/c^2$. Can precision measurements of vacuum fluctuations, gravitational wave stiffness, or next-order corrections to atomic spectra determine m_A to better than $\pm 10\%$?
11. **Physical origin of the inverse-density interaction.** The K_A -invariance constraint uniquely determines the Gross–Pitaevskii nonlinearity as $g(n) = \mu_0 - K_A/n$ (Eq. 8)—an inverse-density interaction that is repulsive at low density and asymptotically constant at high density. What microscopic physics between Aether quanta produces this specific functional form? Candidates include effective multi-body scattering at high density, quantum corrections to the condensate self-energy, or an intrinsic structural property of the Aether’s internal degrees of freedom. Note that this is distinct from the logarithmic Gross–Pitaevskii potential $g(n) = b \ln(n/n_0)$ [40, 41], which yields a linear pressure $P = bn$ (density-independent speed, density-dependent bulk modulus)—the inverse of the Aether’s requirements.
12. **Breaking the ρ_A degeneracy.** The vortex energy equation (12) connects m_e , ρ_A , and m_A through the vortex geometry, but introduces m_A as a new unknown. The system still has one degree of freedom. What additional constraint—from dispersion measurements, gravitational wave coupling, or vacuum impedance—can independently determine ρ_A or m_A and close the system?
13. **Particle mass spectrum from vortex topology.** If the electron is a quantized vortex ring with circulation $\kappa_e = h/(2m_A)$ and loop radius r_{loop} , can the full lepton mass spectrum (electron, muon, tau) be derived from the allowed quantized vortex configurations in the logarithmic condensate? Higher-energy vortex knots, linked rings, or multiply-wound configurations may correspond to heavier particles. Can the baryon masses (proton, neutron) similarly arise from three-vortex composite topologies? The Derrick instability of hedgehog skyrmions (Section 4.7) rules out one class of solitonic particles, but the full classification of stable vortex configurations in a spinor superfluid with logarithmic interactions remains open.
14. **Formal derivation of Bell-violating correlations from the condensate.** The theory provides a physical mechanism for entanglement: correlated excitations of the quantum superfluid condensate inherit non-separable joint states from the condensate’s global wavefunction, and the binding principle ensures that excitations cannot be described independently of the field they are bound to (Section 1.6.1). This mechanism is consistent with all observed entanglement phenomena and has a direct analogue in laboratory BEC pair production [14]. What remains is a formal derivation: starting from the condensate’s field operators and bosonic commutation relations, show that the resulting two-excitation correlation function reproduces exactly the $\cos^2(\theta_A - \theta_B)$ dependence that violates Bell inequalities. This would elevate entanglement from a qualitative prediction to a quantitative one.

8. Proposed Experiments

The following experiments target specific predictions relevant to this paper:

1. **Quadratic Lorentz-violating photon dispersion.** Special relativity predicts that Lorentz invariance is exact at all energies—photons of any frequency travel at exactly c . In the Aether model, Lorentz invariance is emergent and must break down at wavelengths approaching the relevant healing length. For photons (spin-wave excitations), the controlling scale is the *spin* healing length ξ_s , which is much smaller than the density healing length ξ because the spin coupling vastly exceeds the density coupling (Section 4.8). The predicted dispersion relation is $\omega^2 = k^2 c^2 (1 \pm k^2 \xi_s^2)$: a *quadratic* energy dependence, not linear, because the isotropic medium preserves CPT symmetry. Current Fermi LAT constraints require $\xi_s \lesssim 10^{-27}$ m, consistent with the spin-wave channel being $\sim 10^{22}$ times stiffer than the density channel. The Cherenkov Telescope Array (CTA), with its improved sensitivity to time-of-arrival delays from high-redshift gamma-ray bursts, could push the quadratic LIV constraint by one to two orders of magnitude. A detection of quadratic (but not linear) dispersion would be a specific signature of a medium-based theory.
2. **Vacuum birefringence from condensate anisotropy.** Both photon polarizations are spin-wave excitations in the same channel, but they correspond to two transverse directions of the spinor oscillation. If the condensate ground state has any preferred orientation (e.g., residual nematic or ferromagnetic order), the two transverse directions become inequivalent and the polarization states propagate at marginally different speeds—vacuum birefringence. Standard electrodynamics (in the absence of external fields) predicts zero vacuum birefringence. The Aether model predicts $\Delta c/c \sim (E/E_{\text{Planck}})^2$ from any small breaking of rotational symmetry within the spin-wave channel, which is undetectable at optical frequencies but could accumulate over cosmological distances for gamma-ray photons. Polarimetric observations of GRB afterglows and blazar jets already constrain vacuum birefringence at levels approaching $\Delta c/c < 10^{-38}$; future X-ray polarimetry missions (IXPE, eXTP) could tighten these bounds further. A null result would confirm that the condensate ground state is fully isotropic in the spin-wave sector.

For all proposed experiments, see Paper 1: General Overview [35].

9. Mathematical Summary

This section collects the key equations relevant to the topics covered in this paper. *For the complete mathematical summary, see Paper 1: General Overview [35].*

9.1 Fundamental Aether Parameters

The theory posits four microscopic parameters from which all macroscopic phenomena derive:

Symbol	Name	Constrained range	Primary constraint
ρ_A	Ambient density	$10^{11}\text{--}10^{12} \text{ kg/m}^3$	Electron vortex energy
K_A	Bulk modulus	$10^{28}\text{--}10^{29} \text{ J/m}^3$	$K_A = \rho_A c^2$
m_A	Aether quantum mass	$500\text{--}850 \text{ MeV}/c^2$	Flux tube width / glueball mass
ξ	Healing length	$0.17\text{--}0.28 \text{ fm}$	Bridge diameter (lattice QCD)

These four are not independent. Two defining relations connect them:

$$c = \sqrt{K_A/\rho_A} \quad (31)$$

$$\xi = \frac{\hbar}{m_A c \sqrt{2}} \quad (32)$$

leaving two free Aether parameters (e.g., ρ_A and m_A) from which all others follow. (A third parameter, ϵ , enters through gravity; see below.)

9.2 Equation of State

The Aether obeys a logarithmic equation of state, the unique form that produces a density-independent bulk modulus (Section 4):

$$P = K_A \ln\left(\frac{\rho}{\rho_0}\right) + P_0 \quad (33)$$

Key consequence: the speed of sound $c_s = \sqrt{K_A/\rho}$ varies with density. At ambient density, $c_s = c$. Note: in gravitational fields, Bernoulli's equation for free-fall inflow gives $\Delta\rho/\rho_A = 0$ exactly, so c does not vary near gravitating masses; the density dependence is relevant for material media and for the two-fluid cosmological structure where the superfluid fraction varies with temperature. This equation of state guarantees that K_A is constant under compression, which is experimentally confirmed by:

- Velocity time dilation measurements spanning $10^{-6} c$ to $0.9994 c$ (precision $\sim 10^{-8}$).
- The Fresnel drag coefficient $1 - 1/n^2$, exact across materials with density ratios up to $\sim 6:1$.

9.3 Particle Properties from Vortex Topology

Circulation quantum.

$$\kappa_0 = \frac{h}{m_A}, \quad \kappa_e = \frac{h}{2m_A} \quad (\text{half-quantum, electron}) \quad (34)$$

Electron mass from vortex energy.

$$m_e c^2 = \frac{1}{2} \rho_A \kappa_e^2 r_{\text{loop}} \left[\ln(8r_{\text{loop}}/\xi) - \frac{1}{2} \right] \quad (35)$$

with $r_{\text{loop}} \approx \lambda_C = \hbar/(m_e c) \approx 386 \text{ fm}$.

Vortex stability. Multiply quantized vortices ($n \geq 2$) are energetically unstable ($E \propto n^2$, while n single vortices have $E \propto n$), providing the Pauli exclusion principle. Each orbital mode admits at most two opposite-circulation vortices.

Derrick's theorem. Hedgehog skyrmions in the logarithmic condensate have energy $E = AL + BL^3$ with $A, B > 0$; no finite minimum exists. Particles must be quantized vortex rings (Section 4.7).

9.4 Atomic Structure

Ground state energy.

$$E_1 = -\frac{1}{2} \alpha^2 m_e c^2 = -13.6 \text{ eV} \quad (36)$$

Quantization condition. Constructive self-interference in the resonant Aether cavity:

$$n \lambda = 2\pi r \quad (37)$$

Fine structure constant. The electron's orbital velocity as a fraction of the Aether wave speed (atomic Mach number):

$$\alpha = \frac{v_{\text{orbital}}}{c} \approx \frac{1}{137} \quad (38)$$

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